Gojoseon

Also known as Gochoson, Gojoseon is said to have been established in 2,333 BCE according to the Samgukyusa, a 13th century text called the Memorabilia of the Three Kingdoms. Dangun Wangeom was the founder and he was believed by the people to be the son of the deity Hwanung. The fable continues and says that his mother was a she-bear who had taken the form of a woman. Nonetheless, archaeologists have determined that the civilization began as a coalition of several towns close to the Daedong and the Liao River areas sometime between the seventh and fourth centuries BCE. Sima Qian, the famous ancient Chinese historian, mentions the state in his *Records of the Grand Historian*, which is dated to around 100 BCE. There is still some debate as to whether Gojoseon could actually be referred to as a state at this point in time. It is still unclear as to how much territory it controlled, where the capital was located and when it was established.

Gojoseon began to thrive as it made advancements in agriculture by utilizing various natural resources such as zin, gold, copper, silver and tin. Various tools were imported from China and it was around this time that the ondol underground heating system was developed. The earliest Korean stoneware was grey in color and also created around the same time. Gojoseon began to attract the attention of the Yan state around 300 BCE who launched successive attacks into the peninsula. Wiman Joseon of Korea tried to battle the Han Dynasty but failed miserably during the second century BCE. The Han Dynasty effectively established its rule and enacted new laws in favor of China. The Chinese wanted the rich natural resources in Korea and so separated the country into four sections that were governed by the Chinese empire.

The territory once held by Gojoseon changed its name to Goguryeo, also referred to as Koguryo). Meanwhile, the southern part of the peninsula was separated into what is called the Three Hans of Chinhan, Mahan and Pyonhan. These Three Hans were called Silla, Gaya and Baekje during the Three Kingdoms era. Those who had been displaced from Gojoseon migrated south and took with them a complex culture and society.